

4.2 Prose across periods

Paper 4 Pre- and Post-1900 Poetry and Prose · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

A prose essay can combine detailed passage analysis with knowledge of the whole prescribed work. Track shifts in narrative stance, dialogue, description and temporal structure; historical context should sharpen a claim based on words. Critical interpretations can differ, but explain why one fits a passage better.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

An apparent celebration of a grand house may become ironic when the narrator counts unpaid workers in the next sentence; the later detail reframes the earlier praise.

Original practice stimulus

The garden seemed endless to its owner. He described it to guests by naming the trees he had planted and the paths he intended to extend. From the terrace, the iron gate was almost hidden by leaves. For the gardener, however, the gate was the last place the day's wages reached. He left by it at dusk and returned through it before anyone in the house was awake. Once, a visitor asked whether the flowers grew naturally in such ordered rows. The owner smiled and said the place was fortunate in its soil. At the edge of the path, the gardener bent to remove a weed and did not look up.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Original extract: "The garden seemed endless to its owner. For the gardener, the gate was the last place the day's wages reached." Explore how perspective shapes the idea of ownership.

[25]

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong essay contrasts owner/gardener focalisation, “endless” against the wage boundary and possible irony in “seemed.” Move from local language to class relations cautiously; apply method to a chosen 2026 set prose text.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

Syllabus: Literature in English 9695, 2024–2026.

<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/636097-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

Original FagusED teaching material. Question layout and mark presentation informed by the May/June 2026 papers supplied by the user. The practice question is newly written and is not a Cambridge past-paper question.